Film History

Middle Eastern and North African Cinema

From its beginnings, cinema has been a part of the culture of many Middle Eastern and North African countries. But recent widespread civil unrest, revolution, and repression in these countries have had a negative impact on artistic freedom. This, as well as heavy restrictions and censorship by the governments of some of these countries—especially Iran—has not stopped the creation of serious movies, a large number of which were directed by women. Western films are often banned in these countries, leaving room for the development of a cinema rich in social, cultural, and political themes.

For the countries of Algeria, Egypt, Iraq, Iran, Israel, Lebanon, and Palestine, we have compiled a short list of contemporary films to introduce you to the work of directors who have earned a place in world cinema. Other Middle Eastern and North African countries—Bahrain, Jordan, Kuwait, Libya, Morocco, Oman, Saudi Arabia, Somalia, Sudan, Syria, Tunisia, Western Sahara, and Yemen—produce a comparatively smaller output of films that, in turn, are less well known in the West.

Iran

There was a brief New Wave in Iran in the early 1970s. Sohrab Shahid Saless's *Still Life* (1974) is one notable example that influenced the emerging Iranian filmmakers of the mid 1980s. In 1984, Iran set the goal of producing at least 50 films of superior quality a year by making low-budget grants available for films that would be visible on the international market. There were restrictions to obtain these grants: 1.) because women had to be covered when they left the house and when shooting indoor scenes, many Iranian films were shot outdoors or inside cars. Neorealism heavily influenced these 1980s films and many of them revolve around children. Many feature nonprofessional actors.

Abbas Kiarostami

Abbas Kiarostami began to write and direct films in the 1970s. He came to international attention in the mid 1980s with the first part of a trilogy called *Where is the Friend's Home?* (1987) about a boy returning his friend's homework. In the second part of the trilogy, *Life, and Nothing More* (1992), a man (resembling Kiarostami) drives with his son to where *Where is the Friend's Home*? was shot to see if the children he filmed are OK after an earthquake. In the third film of the Koker trilogy, *Through the Olive Trees* (1994), Kiarostami revisits an episode involving shooting a scene from *Life, and Nothing More*. Kiarostami's films are Neorealist in spirit and method, but are never violent or sentimental.

Kiarostami's *Five Dedicated to Ozu* consists of 5 long shots, each averaging about 16 minutes each and mostly utilizing a fixed camera. As in a typical Ozu film, the camera never moves, zooms or pans. There is no dialogue and except for the first shot. People are not the focus of the film.

***Five Dedicated to Ozu* (Abbas Kiarostami, 2003)**

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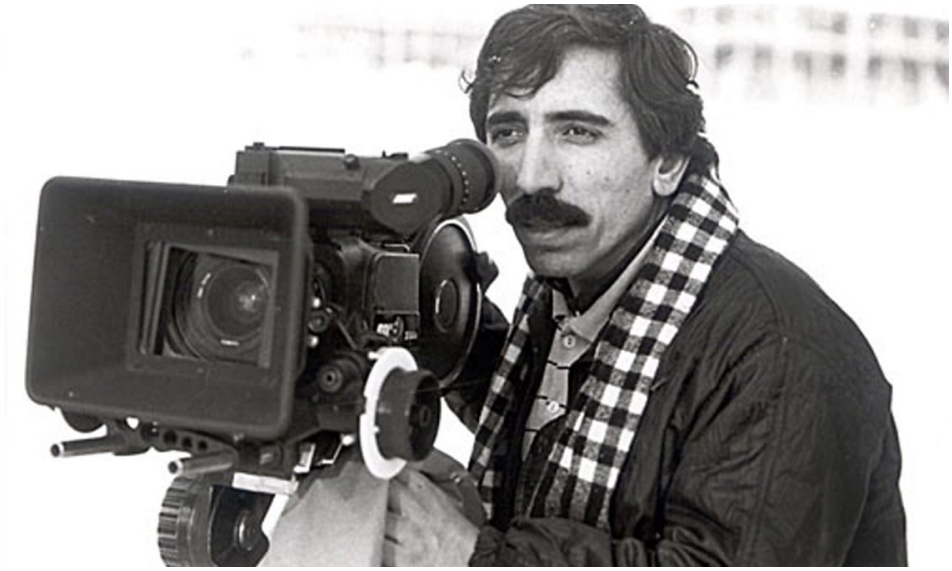
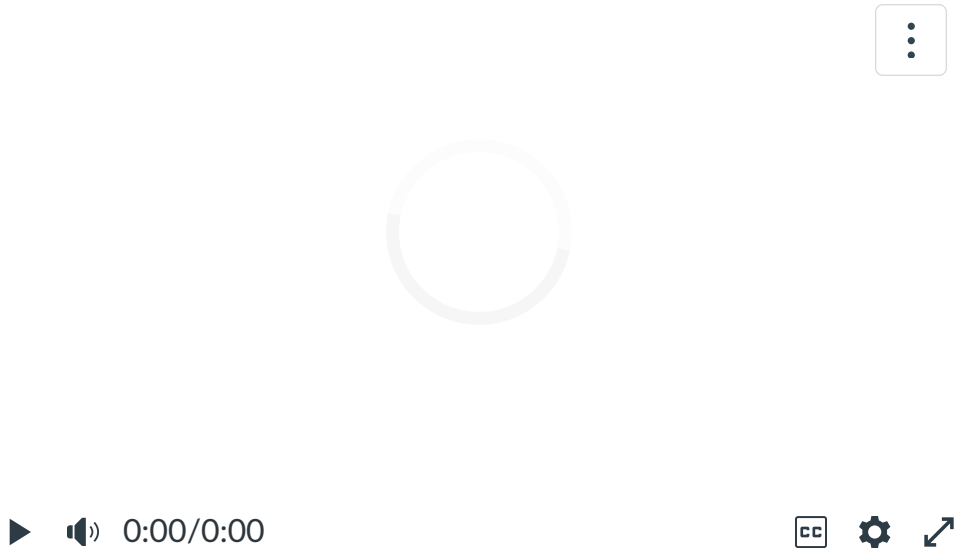
Mohsen Makhmalbaf has worked in a variety of styles including neorealism and Expressionism. He is the subject of the Abbas Kiarostami film *Close-Up* (1990) in which a man who in real life impersonated Makhmalbaf reenacts how he duped a family who takes him in.



Mohsen Makhmalbaf

In *Salaam Cinema* (1995), Makhmalbaf shoots in a documentary style and shows the audition process of a film he is casting. He puts an ad in the paper and thousands of people show up. They think they are auditioning for his next film and are unaware that the film is the "audition." In the following scene, Makhmalbaf asks a group of men auditioning for a role to

replicate an action scene. One man explains his preference for melodramas over action films.

***Salaam Cinema* (Mohsen Makhmalbaf, 1995)**